Developments in the spring and summer of 1965, however, would lead to disillusionment and a fraying of the US-India ties. The Vietnam War would bring to the fore differences in the two countries' approaches to China and highlight the different levels of importance the two countries placed on India's relations with the Soviet Union.[176] Increasing India-Pakistan tension led to Delhi questioning the reliability of US assurances. It also resulted in frustration in Washington about the lack of Indian focus on the main threat —China—and made it harder to justify assistance to India when its defense–development priorities seemed to be skewed. Finally, Johnson's decision to hold back—and eventually suspend—both guns and butter from India made Delhi question the American commitment to helping it meet the external and internal China challenge.

Vietnam: Dueling Approaches

After a visit to India in spring 1965, Harriman optimistically wrote to the president about the US and India's "full agreement on such matters as aggressive intents of Red China, need to prevent Reds' take-over in South Vietnam and [Southeast Asia]." But "they are, of course, still suspicious and fearful of some of our policies and methods." This was especially the case regarding Vietnam. The Johnson administration saw its actions as designed to contain the Chinese threat. It thought that Delhi was not pulling its weight on an issue on which the two sides should have agreed. But India worried that the US military approach and Washington's view of the Soviet Union exacerbated the Chinese threat.[177]

India had looked at developments in Southeast Asia partly through a China prism and partly through a postcolonial one. By the early 1960s, the desire to limit Chinese influence in Southeast Asia had been the more pressing Indian concern. Delhi feared a vacuum or instability in Vietnam that Beijing could exploit. Policymakers had concerns about any American (and Soviet) intervention that could create the conditions for such a Chinese role, but they had also worried about any hasty American—or more broadly Western—withdrawal. Key officials in the Indian government had also come to see North Vietnamese support for Viet Cong guerrillas in South Vietnam as destabilizing.[178]

But Delhi had still not been as forthcoming or as public in its support for the US position as Washington would have liked. In 1961, Nehru, for